

Judging a work of art



Greek culture flourished in the classical period. In the time of the great Athenian philosophers, it produced great works of poetry, theatre, music, architecture and art. Not everyone recognized their excellence, however – Plato, for example, distrusted all the arts as distracting and poor imitations of the ideal Forms of beauty and goodness. But how then *should* we judge a work of art? If we simply regard it as a matter of taste, we run the risk of confusing our emotional response with an objective appraisal, the so-called ‘affective fallacy’. It may be just as misleading to seek meaning in art: we may try to discover the artist’s intention, but find this at odds with our

appraisal of his or her work. In the case of Wagner, for example, do his repugnant racism and personal arrogance detract from the worth of his music, or is this an instance of the 'intentional fallacy'? Modern art often falls outside of our narrow definitions, and forgeries and reproductions challenge our perceptions of the role of the artist, raising the perennial question, 'What is art?'